

- **Skulltag:** A massively multi-player online variant of Doom.
- **Oil Rush:** This is a naval theme-based real-time strategy game. Apart from Linux, the game is available for Windows, Mac and PS3.

Some of the above titles are pretty interesting.

However, the sad part here is that most game developers for Linux are not 'innovating'—the RPGs on Linux seem to be clones of the well-known RPGs for Windows, and so on. Sure, such games are awesome to play, and very well maintained, but a tinge of innovation in terms of thinking will definitely be better than simply cloning the existing games in the same genre.

Games that can be run via compatibility layers

Arguably, the majority of gamers on Linux run games via compatibility layers (which means launching games that are not exactly built for Linux, using a compatibility application). The most well-known application for this is Wine. Many games tend to run perfectly well under Wine, and the Wine creators themselves are well aware of the fact that the package is used by gamers. The list of games that run well on Wine is constantly updated on the website, with ratings from the community. This list is huge, but for the record, let me name a few:

- **Final Fantasy XI:** A well-known MMORPG (massively multiplayer online RPG)
- **StarCraft I Retail:** A sci-fi action and adventure game.
- **Counter-Strike:** A squad-based tactical FPS.
- **Left 4 Dead:** A multi-player horror survival FPS.
- **Guild Wars:** An episodic multi-player RPG.

Obviously, all these are big names. Quite frankly, if you intend to play games on Linux, you should install Wine.

All the above-mentioned games are clubbed under the Platinum list—that is, the games that install and run flawlessly under Wine. There are other lists too, each showing the level of performance of the given application, under Wine.

Interestingly, many proprietary firms have been porting their games to Linux, of late—a trend that has gained great momentum since the second half of 2011. As of now, Codeweavers has set up a separate section for porting its games to Linux and other UNIX platforms, namely, Crossover Games.

Others, such as PlayOnLinux and Steamgames on Linux, have come up simply due to the success of Wine. Steamgames, for instance, tests games specifically meant to run under Wine, not native Linux. PlayOnLinux is also based on Wine. It lets you install and run many Windows games and apps—all for free.

And lastly, as with any open source project, you can also contribute towards tweaking and optimising your favourite games' performance under Wine or PlayOnLinux.

Games that can be played/streamed online

The Internet has been expanding at a great pace. With the advent of modern browsers, Internet gaming has also acquired a new shape and form, and is no longer restricted to mere Flash games. Until now, Internet gaming had been viewed as mere casual stuff, but of late, the trend is changing. Of course, the multi-player games are also played online, but the rise in popularity that we are talking about right now is that of browser-based gaming.

Have you heard of the service Online? If not, well, it lets you run games. Nothing new there, right? Actually, Online can let you run games on its own server, rather than on your computer. Imagine that you like a particular game, which is not yet supported on Linux. Simple! Head on to Online, and play your game using their servers. The audio/video and other data is streamed live to your browser! On the downside, this requires a wonderful Internet connection!

There isn't any official client for Online on Linux devices, but you can attempt to run the non-Linux clients under Wine.

Final words

To begin with, native game developers for Linux are working at a great pace, and while there is still a lot to be done, we have seen a flood of amazing outputs in the past one year, and the second quarter of 2012 surely looks to be even more promising. Furthermore, Wine lets you run many non-Linux games with negligible tweaking, and is definitely a good option to consider. So, the bottom-line is that though we still lag behind the proprietary gaming world, our options are increasing fast. It will be safe to expect a flood of games as 2012 comes to a close. 

References

- WSJ.com — 'When Gaming is Good For You' goo.gl/NKz50

Useful Links

- Gaming on Linux: www.gamingonlinux.com/
- Happy Penguin: www.happy.penguin.org/
- Codeweavers Crossover Games: www.codeweavers.com/products/cxgames/
- Linux Games: www.linuxgames.com/
- PlayOnLinux: www.playonlinux.com/
- SteamGames on Linux: www.steamgamesonlinux.com/
- Wine Applications Database: appdb.winehq.org/
- Online: www.online.com/

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